

Chapter 22

Monday, noon.

Yin Lingzhu simply packed her luggage, and the three of them entered the production crew together.

Since the show was completely closed off, each group would be assigned a dormitory.

During official recording, everyone's phones would be confiscated.

The dormitory had a loft bed with a desk underneath, and the bedding had already been arranged. After they moved in, they only needed to organize their own luggage.

"In previous seasons, the dormitories were all bunk beds. We're very lucky." Wan Miaoyin said casually while putting clothes into the wardrobe.

"I know. I heard the production team recently secured a major investment." Kong Murui picked up her words.

Yin Lingzhu had already lain down on the bed and didn't speak, immersed in her own world. She was thinking about the performance in a few days.

This show had a lot of traffic. Whether she could become somewhat popular depended on this time.

While Yin Lingzhu was calculating in her mind, she felt someone shaking her arm—it was Wan Miaoyin.

"Let's go, time to eat." She held up her phone, where the group chat had just sent a notification.

Yin Lingzhu hummed in response, and the three of them followed the crowd to the cafeteria.

"You're eating so little—can your body handle it?" Wan Miaoyin looked at Yin Lingzhu's plate, which only had a few vegetables and a pitiful amount of meat.

Hearing the voice, Yin Lingzhu looked down. Indeed, there was very little food on her plate. She quietly touched her stomach—fortunately, she wasn't very hungry right now.

She smiled at the two of them, "It's fine. I ate a lot this morning, so I'm eating less now."

After speaking, she lowered her head again, secretly recalling what had just happened.

She had seen a figure that looked ninety percent like Yan Si, which is why she hadn't paid attention to the food on her plate.

She picked up a vegetable with her chopsticks and put it in her mouth, chewing slowly. The slightly sweet taste spread in her mouth, diluting the inexplicable emotions in her heart.

It was probably just a case of mistaken identity.

Wan Miaoyin finished her last bite and picked up her phone to check notifications that had come during their meal.

"The assigned practice room is ready. Should we go take a look?" After checking her phone, she asked the other two.

The three of them looked at the room in front of them with slight surprise. The practice room was much larger than the one at their company.

Kong Murui ran inside and turned on the huge TV hanging on the wall.

The smooth startup speed, clear screen, and comfortable visual experience made Kong Murui feel as if she were in another world.

Yin Lingzhu noticed that her eyes were full of emotion, as if she was about to cry, and felt a bit surprised, "Are you okay?"

She didn't know Kong Murui's family background and spoke carefully.

"Captain, you don't know what our studio's TV looks like." Kong Murui's voice trembled as she looked pitifully at Yin Lingzhu.

Wan Miaoyin stood nearby, noticed Kong Murui's state, and quietly and quickly left the practice room.

Yin Lingzhu noticed Wan Miaoyin's movement and was left confused by her behavior. Before she could think more about it, she heard Kong Murui's voice again.

"Our TV—I suspect the company picked it up from a garbage dump and refurbished it."

"You have to slap it a few times when turning it on for it to work, and sometimes it restarts. Captain, do you know?"

Yin Lingzhu nodded.

"Every time I see the pixels on our TV, I feel like it's hurting my eyes. Captain, do you know?"

Yin Lingzhu nodded.

For the next hour of complaints, Yin Lingzhu was only responsible for nodding woodenly.

Yin Lingzhu not only gained a comprehensive understanding of TV construction but also deeply understood why Wan Miaoyin had left early.

Finally, Yin Lingzhu didn't know how she got back to the dormitory. Her mind held only one thought: she must replace that broken TV.

"I just got some news. We might have a special guest judge this time." Wan Miaoyin returned to the room and, seeing everyone was there, spoke up.

Hearing the words "special guest," Yin Lingzhu instinctively thought of Yan Si's previous maneuvers.

"Do you know who it is?" She moved her gaze from the dance moves playing on screen and asked.

Wan Miaoyin shook her head.

Yin Lingzhu could only hope in her heart that the special guest judge wasn't Yan Si.

She had no idea how to face Yan Si right now—she was avoiding her.

Yin Lingzhu nodded, indicating she understood.

She turned her attention back to her phone screen, which was showing last season's program.

Looking at the TV displayed in the practice room, Yin Lingzhu secretly glanced at Kong Murui and, seeing she wasn't looking her way, felt relieved.

The screen was playing behind-the-scenes footage where an idol was vigorously slapping the TV. After finally getting a picture, the idol's face showed a smile.

It was both heartbreaking and funny.

Yin Lingzhu became even more determined that after this show ended, she must replace the studio's TV.

Early the next morning, the director notified everyone to gather in the main hall.

Yin Lingzhu discovered that her hopes indeed hadn't come true.

Looking at Yan Si in front of her, her mind was in turmoil.

Today, Yan Si wore a high-end black dress, her lips painted with matte red lipstick. The corners of her mouth curved upward, and her eyes stared directly at Yin Lingzhu.

Everyone was startled to see Yan Si's presence, then after recovering, their faces showed excited expressions.

They knew that with Yan Si's presence, this show would definitely be a hit.

Yin Lingzhu stepped back, avoiding Yan Si's gaze.

She still harbored some hope that Yan Si might be here for other reasons.

"Our content has changed this time. Previously, we would edit the footage first and then broadcast it."

"This season will be in live broadcast format, streaming on all platforms."

"Today you can rest for another day—the cameras won't be activated. Tomorrow we'll officially start recording."

After the director finished speaking, he inconspicuously glanced at Yan Si. Seeing she had no intention of speaking, he announced that everyone could leave.

Yan Si watched Yin Lingzhu's retreating figure, her eyes holding both confusion and determination.

"Camera equipment should also be prepared for all members' rooms." She said lightly.

Catching this instruction, the director immediately had his subordinates take action.

In the dormitory, Yin Lingzhu had just closed the door when she heard Kong Murui exclaim in surprise.

"What's wrong?" Yin Lingzhu quickly asked.

Kong Murui handed her phone to Yin Lingzhu, letting her see for herself.

"Isn't this an invasion of privacy?" She sat nearby, dejected and complaining.

Yin Lingzhu returned the phone to her and sat silently at her own spot.

The production team's notification not only mentioned installing cameras but also said that due to the change in broadcast format, they needed to sign another contract.

If they disagreed with the live broadcast format, they could withdraw from the competition, and the production team would agree.

At the same time, those who confirmed their withdrawal could receive compensation. The new contract would reach their managers today.

Yin Lingzhu understood that with Yan Si's presence in this show, it would be impossible for anyone to withdraw.

She looked at Kong Murui, who was criticizing the production team, then at Wan Miaoyin, who had been silent with furrowed brows.

Both showed dissatisfaction, but Yin Lingzhu knew clearly that they wouldn't quit. Dissatisfaction was one thing, staying was another.

Among those who came to participate in the show, who didn't want to debut¹?

She sighed and briefly explained the situation to her manager.

Yang Daiyi immediately called.

"You must sign!!! What a great opportunity!!!!"

After saying this, Yang Daiyi suddenly realized the relationship between Yan Si and Yin Lingzhu.

"Are you okay with this?"

Yang Daiyi's excited voice instantly became smaller. Yin Lingzhu found it amusing.

"I'm fine. This opportunity is rare for them." Yin Lingzhu said.

After just thinking through the pros and cons, she actually understood.

She had to seize this opportunity, whether for the team or for herself.

She couldn't give up such an opportunity because of her emotions.

"That's good. When the contract arrives, I'll sign it."

After hanging up, Yin Lingzhu left the room. She wanted to go out for some fresh air.

Not knowing where to go, Yin Lingzhu wandered randomly and found herself at the practice room.

Noticing a figure at the practice room door, she instinctively held her breath and tried to quietly leave.

Yan Si noticed her and immediately stepped in front of her. Unlike her usual cold expression, she said with a smile, "So unwilling to see me?"

Footnotes:

¹ **Debut (出道):** In the Chinese entertainment industry, this refers to officially entering the entertainment business as a professional performer, typically through participation in talent shows, signing with agencies, or other formal means of launching a career in music, acting, or other entertainment fields.